

The heart

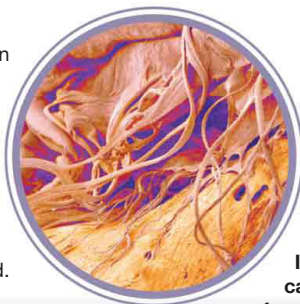
The heart is the powerhouse of the circulatory system. It beats around 70 times a minute to push blood around the body. The heart is made of cardiac muscle, which never tires.

Inside the heart

The heart has a left and a right side, each with two chambers—the atrium and the ventricle. The right side of the heart pumps blood to the lungs, while the left side pumps blood to the body. Valves stop the blood from flowing in the wrong direction.

Heart strings are thin cords attached to the valve between each atrium and ventricle.

When the heart beats, these strings stop the valve from turning inside out like an umbrella in a strong wind.



Superior vena cava
carries blood into
the right atrium

**Right
atrium**

**Valve between
the atrium and
ventricle**

**Right
ventricle**

**Inferior vena
cava** carries blood
from the lower body
to the right atrium

